

“RED”

A Call of Cthulhu Scenario Set in 1920s Rhode Island

Scenario Overview

In the year 1920, the Investigators each receive a frantic letter from **Dr. Carl**, a respected physician in the remote town of **Nestorac** (in rural Rhode Island). In his letter, Dr. Carl pleads for help in uncovering the source of a mysterious disease spreading through the town—one that causes fever, coughing, and, strangely, periodic memory loss. He offers to cover the costs of the investigation out of his own savings.

The Investigators arrive in Nestorac to find it surrounded by rugged valleys and mountains, nearly cut off from the outside world. The disease is worsening, and rumors swirl of bizarre rites, red-robed workers, and an ancient evil sealed beneath the town. As the Investigators delve deeper, they discover that not all is what it seems. Their efforts will eventually bring them face-to-face with the horrifying truth of “**the Ancestor**,” a monstrous creation that threatens to drown the world in a crimson tide of corruption—unless they stop it first.

Keeper’s Information

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Investigator Hooks

1. **Professional Curiosity:** Dr. Carl’s urgent letter specifically requests medical or scientific expertise, appealing to Investigators with a background in medicine, biology, or the sciences.
2. **Personal Connection:** One of the Investigators has a friend or relative (perhaps **Agnes**) who has recently fallen ill in Nestorac.
3. **Sense of Duty:** Newspapers have begun reporting rumors of a strange epidemic. Concerned philanthropists, a university department, or even the federal government may quietly sponsor a group to investigate.

If additional motivations or special reasons are needed for your particular group, insert them here: **[add further Investigator hooks as needed]**.

Setting: Nestorac

- **Location:** A small, secluded town in Rhode Island, ringed by mountains and forests.
- **Atmosphere:** Perpetually hazy. Dust drifts along the unpaved streets, casting a reddish hue in the sunlight. Locals seem exhausted and on edge.
- **Landmarks:** The town is dominated by four primary structures—
 - **North:** The **Library & City Hall** (two floors in the same building)
 - **West:** The **Clock Tower**
 - **East:** The **Factory**
 - **South:** The **Cemetery**

Brief Timeline

1. **Arrival:** The Investigators meet Dr. Carl, who explains the outbreak and provides them with essential supplies (12 cans of food, 12 cans of water).
 2. **Rising Tension:** As they investigate, they notice the disease's contradictory symptoms—locals claim it causes memory loss, but Dr. Carl's experiments show no sign of amnesia.
 3. **Deepening Mystery:** Exploration of the town's key locations reveals disturbing evidence of an ancient, blood-soaked presence sealed beneath the town.
 4. **Climax:** A final confrontation in the subterranean caverns below the Clock Tower, where the Investigators may find the monstrous "Ancestor."
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Major Chapters & Locations

Below is a suggested structure for the Keeper to guide the Investigators through the scenario. Feel free to adapt and reorder as needed.

Chapter 1: Meeting Dr. Carl

- **Summary:** The Investigators arrive at Dr. Carl's home.
- **Key Points:**
 - Dr. Carl provides a briefing on the disease.
 - He insists the Investigators eat only from canned food (he believes there's something contaminated in the town).
 - **Clue:** Dr. Carl's notes reveal that, in controlled experiments, no patient has ever actually experienced memory loss, contrary to local claims.
 - **Role-Playing:** Dr. Carl, although deeply concerned, tries to appear calm. He's spent his life savings hiring outside help.

- **Potential Twist:** Dr. Carl may later disappear under mysterious circumstances. His corpse might turn up in the cemetery acid pit, suggesting a cover-up.

If any background on Dr. Carl is missing, insert it here: [Add Dr. Carl's background if needed].

Chapter 2: Town Exploration

Investigators will likely explore the streets of Nestorac and encounter individuals or ephemeral clues that foreshadow the bigger horrors.

- **Strange Street Scene**
 - **Description:** People shuffle by listlessly; every sound (footsteps, breathing) is unnaturally amplified. Occasional gusts of wind stirs up red-tinged dust.
 - **Encounters:**
 - **Red-Robed Workers** acting strangely (like red blood cells, they move supplies around the town).
 - **White-Clad Guards** (like white blood cells), patrolling and seeming hostile or suspicious.
 - **Clue:** A bloodstained scrap of paper warns, "**White is dangerous—stay away from those in white.**"
 - **Possible Side Quests:**
 - **Penny:** A local who has become infected and claims to have lost her memory. Investigators might bring her to Dr. Carl for an examination.
 - **Agnes:** Another local with a missing address or uncertain whereabouts. [Add details as desired].
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Chapter 3: The Library & City Hall (North)

- **Appearance:** A large building whose first floor is a maze-like library with haphazardly placed bookshelves. The second floor houses the city administration offices.
- **Hazards:**
 - Electrical wires dangle overhead, occasionally sparking; investigating after working hours may be safer.
 - Library corridors form a confusing labyrinth.
- **Key Clues:**
 - **Town History Display** at the library's center:
 - Nestorac was once flooded by a week-long deluge.
 - Another time, the town was shrouded in darkness for seven consecutive days.
 - Hints of cyclical catastrophes tied to cosmic forces.

- **Hidden Door to a Cellar:**
 - A single glowing drop of water that, when touched, gives a vision of “countless gods, shadows, and floods.”
 - Suggests the primeval chaos that once afflicted the world.
 - **“Creation” Texts:**
 - **Creation (Above):** “All creation stems from cold water, rancid blood, and ethereal aether. In that swirling mixture, gods and monsters rose.”
 - **Creation (Middle):** “From beyond time rose three barriers:
 - *Iserolor*, the Wall of the Sky, sealed the whispering gods above.
 - *Svarilkus*, the Wall of the Sea, sealed the dread creatures below.
 - *Simos*, the Wall of Blood, bound foul blood and twisted shadows into mortal flesh.”
 - **Creation (Below):** [Investigators must piece together from other notes or Keeper’s discretion].
 - **Mysterious Note:** “Rationality is the mask of the madman; logic is the throat and tongue of insanity.”
 - **City Hall (Second Floor):**
 - Staffed by **Gray-Clad Administrators** (like the “gray matter” of the brain).
 - Possible NPC: **Hobbson**, once an explorer, now subdued and working in city records.
 - **Clue:** Official records may reveal the town’s name is an anagram of “Ancestor.”
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Chapter 4: The Clock Tower (West)

- **Exterior & Entry:** A looming structure that chimes every hour. Rumors say the caretaker has gone mad, relentlessly maintaining a tower that might not even work.
- **Atmosphere:**
 - Damp, echoing interior. A pendulum’s ticking resonates in the darkness.
 - Corpses or mannequins suspended like clock pendulums, some missing their heads.
- **Temporal Puzzle:**
 - Investigators must time their climb to avoid bizarre “transformations” triggered at the top of each hour.
 - The clock’s hands have mysteriously stopped, yet the bell still rings from deep underground.
- **Hazards:**
 - **Mechanical “Shells”**—creatures that appear to be human but have twisted gears and pulsating organs beneath metal plating. They may attack intruders.
 - If the Investigators linger too long, they risk becoming “part of the clock.”
- **Goal:**
 - Reach the belfry before the hour is up. The tower itself has begun to collapse in places.

- Possible infiltration from below: The factory's subterranean "blood river" leads to the tower's basement.
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Chapter 5: The Factory (East)

- **Overview:** The factory belches thick smoke across the sky, possibly the source of the strange illness. The interior is a labyrinth of massive pistons, catwalks, and dangerously shifting machinery.
 - **Encounter:**
 1. **Normal Worker "Franz"** and gambling addict **"Thorn"** might be found here. One of them may have turned into a red-robed laborer (a hint of the town's monstrous transformation).
 2. **Red Cultists** worship an entity known as "Simos," the keeper of the Blood Wall.
 - **Key Points:**
 1. **Machinery & Ventilation:** Investigators might need to shut down fans or open vents to navigate toxic areas safely.
 2. **Puzzle with Levers:** Cranking different levers reroutes steam and power, altering the factory's layout.
 3. **Subterranean Level:** A network of catwalks above a "blood river"—the place from which the Investigators can row a small boat into the Clock Tower basement.
 4. **Note:** "Red is the bond between people. In the fever dream, everything is red yet deserted."
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Chapter 6: The Cemetery (South)

- **Appearance:** An industrial "Crypt of Dead Dreams," where the deceased are dissolved in strong acid to save space and money.
- **Structure:**
 - A large, old metal building. The stench of garbage and acidic waste is overpowering.
 - **Observation Walkways:** Suspended above acid pits where bodies dissolve.
- **Hazards:**
 - **Acidic Vapors** can cause damage if Investigators lack protective gear.
 - Walls may shift or lock behind them; the place is designed to keep bodies (and intruders) from escaping.
 - Gigantic mosquitoes mutated by the Ancestor's blood buzz overhead.
- **Crucial Discoveries:**
 - **Bodies:** Investigators may find the remains of Dr. Carl, Franz, Hobbson, or other known townsfolk—some partially dissolved.

- **Records:** In the staff office, cryptic logs reveal the alarming growth in the number of bodies processed.
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Chapter 7: Confrontation in the Underground

Eventually, the Investigators trace the source of the infection and cult activities to **deep caverns** beneath the Clock Tower, accessible either through the tower itself or via the factory's sub-level blood river.

- **Entry:** A **massive gate** guarded by red crystals dripping blood. Each drop morphs into a humanoid figure upon hitting the ground.
 - **The Red Crystals:** Lining the cavern ceiling like stalactites, they pulse with an otherworldly glow.
 - **The Final Door:**
 - At the top of a flight of blood-soaked steps.
 - The thunderous tolling of the clock can be heard from within.
 - Any half-lucid cultist might ask riddles about the "Ancestor" or "Simos" before granting entry.
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Chapter 8: The Ancestor's Chamber

Inside, the Investigators find:

- **Biomechanical Temple:** White, arc-shaped pillars rise from the floor, forming a rib-like enclosure. Drumming echoes throughout like a universal heartbeat.
- **Phases of the Battle** (*Keeper's Choice*):
 - **Unholy Catalyst:** The red cult tries to combine "Ancient Water," "Time's Sand," and "Corpse Salt" to resurrect or empower the Ancestor.
 - **Blood Surge:** The room floods with living, writhing blood, forming limb-like protrusions that drag Investigators down.
 - **Simos's Edicts** ("律令"):
 - **Silence** (默): Players cannot speak or coordinate.
 - **Certainty** (成): The next action automatically succeeds or fails at Keeper's discretion.
 - **Isolation** (孤): If Investigators are within 5 meters of each other, each loses 2d20 SAN due to intense paranoia.
 - **Toil** (碌): A forced Constitution-based test representing unstoppable labor or exhaustion.
- **The Ancestor's Form:** A colossal being formed of swirling, congealed blood and shadow.
 - **Attacks:**

- *Mold Flesh*: 1d4 damage, shapes the victim's body.
 - *Mental Shackles*: 1d4 SAN loss.
 - *Hand of Mercy*: Spectral hands offering "salvation," luring the weak-willed into immobility.
 - *Eye of Judgment*: A disembodied eye that attempts to stun or incapacitate Investigators.
 - **Climactic Decision**: Investigators must disrupt the ritual and/or seal away the Ancestor once more. They might have to use the "Catalyst" incorrectly or destroy the crystals.
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Resolution & Aftermath

- If the Investigators **succeed**, the Ancestor's partial manifestation collapses, and the blood dissipates from the chamber. Half of the townspeople "wake up," having no recollection of their feverish mania. Others disintegrate into red dust that vanishes in the sunlight.
 - If the Investigators **fail**, the Ancestor rises fully, bringing forth an endless "sea of blood." The campaign ends in cosmic doom—or sets the stage for a sequel.
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Key Non-Player Characters

Below is a sample of notable NPCs. Incorporate them (or rename them) as fits your table. If you need additional background or motivations, insert them with **[what's needed there]**.

1. **Dr. Carl**
 - Town doctor, originally summoned the Investigators. Later found dead or missing under suspicious circumstances.
 - Motivations: Desperate to stop the disease.
2. **Penny**
 - An infected local who insists she's losing her memory. May unwittingly act as a test subject for Dr. Carl.
3. **Agnes Thorne**
 - Townsfolk rumored to be hospitalized or in hiding. **[Expand details as desired]**
4. **Franz**
 - A normal factory worker who disappears, possibly "iterated" into a red-robed figure.
5. **Hobbson**
 - A former explorer turned gray-clad records clerk. Possibly also found dissolved in the cemetery acid pit.
6. **Red Cultist "Craine"**

- Leading the summoning ritual of the Ancestor. Possibly the mysterious “red priest.”
 - 7. **“Thorn” (Gambler)**
 - Another contact in the factory or found in the local tavern. Has hidden stimulants, potions, or black-market items.
 - 8. **Other Named Figures**
 - *Dr. Alistair Craine, Eleanor Whitlock, Rev. Gideon Hawthorne, Harold Penrose, Agnes Thorne (again), Barnabas Harker, Martha Caldwell, Jonas Abernathy, Lydia Coldwater, Ezra Vale, Clara Finch, Theophilus Grey, Lucius Cromwell, Iris Wren, Samuel Reed, Margaret Ashcroft, Captain Elias Marlowe, Victoria Northcote, Carl Grey, etc.*
 - These names may serve as additional townsfolk, cultists, or victims.
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Additional Hooks & Elements

1. **“Mechanized Worship”**: Nightly, strange contraptions roll through the streets, collecting “tithes” of blood from unwilling participants.
 2. **“Acid Funeral”**: One Investigator might witness the disposal of a known NPC’s corpse, gleaning vital clues from objects not yet fully dissolved.
 3. **“Catalyst Items”**:
 - *Ancient Water*: Possibly found in the library cellar.
 - *Time’s Sand*: Maybe hidden in the Clock Tower’s upper mechanism.
 - *Corpse Salt*: Harvested from dissolved bodies in the cemetery.
 4. **Role-Playing Tension**: Paranoia grows as memory lapses spread. Who’s truly infected or loyal to the cult?
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Optional Epilogue

If the Investigators manage to save Nestorac—or at least halt the Ancestor’s awakening—life in the valley goes on with only distant nightmares of the dreaded red tide. But rumors persist of **blood crystals** deep underground, waiting for another opportunity to break free.

Should the Keeper wish to continue the storyline:

- **Seed a Future Scenario**: Perhaps the next “wall”—the barrier of the sea or sky—shows signs of weakening in another part of the world.
 - **Investigator Rewards**: Surviving Investigators might gain a special insight (or a permanent madness) related to the cosmic triad of Blood, Water, and Aether.
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Notes on Missing Information

Wherever the text has **[what's needed there]**, feel free to insert:

- More detailed stats for NPCs.
 - Exact spells or rituals the Ancestor's cult employs.
 - Additional Mythos tomes or artifacts.
 - Specific skill checks (e.g., Library Use rolls, Mechanical Repair difficulties, etc.).
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Keeper Advice

- Emphasize **horror through discovery**: The more the Investigators learn about Nestorac's hidden nature, the more disquieting it becomes.
 - Use **body-horror** imagery: Flesh merging with gears, the color red staining everything, people operating like cogs in a ghastly machine.
 - Dole out **Mythos Lore** gradually so the Investigators piece together the cosmic scope behind the disease and the sealed entity.
 - **Pacing**: While there are four major locations, feel free to let the players tackle them in any order. The final confrontation should be time-sensitive, especially as the "red rites" near completion.
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Conclusion

"Red" is a layered horror scenario in which the Investigators unravel the terrifying truth that Nestorac is more than just a remote town—it's a beating "organ" in a grand, horrific organism. As they confront the creeping influence of an ancient blood-god and struggle against forced "mechanization," they may save the townspeople from a fate worse than death—or be consumed by the bloody tide themselves.

Should anything be missing—specific stats, deeper NPC backstories, or location maps—insert them with **[what's needed there]** and tailor the scenario to your group's preferences. Good luck, Keeper, and remember: **"Rationality is but the mask of the madman."**